

Music Education as a Gateway to Entrepreneurship and Economic Growth in Nigeria: A Qualitative Synthesis of Secondary Evidence

¹ Dora I. OKUNBOR

Abstract

Entrepreneurship has become an indispensable mechanism for addressing youth unemployment in Nigeria. While music education is often perceived primarily as an academic and artistic discipline, its potential as a practical pathway to entrepreneurship and economic growth has received limited consolidated attention in the Nigerian context. This study adopted a qualitative research design based on secondary sources of data. Peer-reviewed journal articles, books, industry reports, and statistical releases from the National Bureau of Statistics (NBS), as reported by Business Day (2024), were reviewed and subjected to thematic analysis following Braun and Clarke's (2006) six-phase framework. The analysis focused on identifying recurring themes relating to music-related entrepreneurial pathways, competencies, and contributions to economic growth. The synthesis suggests that formal university music education in Nigeria potentially equips learners with a diverse range of entrepreneurial competencies, including music composition, music production, music marketing, music performance, music technology, sound design and engineering, music management, and music therapy. The literature indicates that these competencies align with contemporary forms of music entrepreneurship, including portfolio careers, freelance and gig work, digital entrepreneurship, intellectual property exploitation, production services, and creative self-employment. Despite acknowledged limitations in data availability, including poor record-keeping and a high rate of unregistered creative enterprises, NBS data reported by Business Day (2024) indicated that Nigeria's movie, music and entertainment industries grew by 27.46% between 2020 and 2023, rising from N1.55 trillion to N1.97 trillion. The study concludes that music education should be recognised as a viable pathway to entrepreneurship and recommends strengthened investment in practical facilities, improved registration and data management of creative enterprises, and enhanced integration of music business and media practices into the curriculum.

Keywords: Entrepreneurship; Music Education; Entrepreneurial Pathways; Economic Growth; Creative Economy

Introduction

Entrepreneurship has become an indispensable mechanism for addressing the current spate of youth unemployment in Nigeria. Entrepreneurship entails the identification of opportunities, mobilisation of resources, and establishment and management of sustainable ventures that generate value for the entrepreneur, employees, and society at large. Achieving this requires the acquisition of relevant knowledge and skills that facilitate job creation, production of goods and services, and effective business management.

Music education, which is often perceived as purely artistic, is in fact a science, an art and a practical discipline that imparts knowledge, skills and discipline required for productive

¹ **Corresponding author:** Dora I. OKUNBOR, PhD, Department of Music, University of Delta, Agbor, Delta State, Nigeria
Email: dora.okunbor@unidel.edu.ng

engagement in society. In Nigeria, formal music education is predominantly delivered through certificate, diploma, and degree programmes in universities, colleges of education and polytechnics, with curricula comprising theory, musicianship, performance, composition, technology and business-related modules. However, although previous studies have examined entrepreneurship and economic growth, and others have examined the nature of music, there is limited consolidated analysis of how competencies acquired through formal music education align with entrepreneurial pathways and economic growth in Nigeria. This gap is exacerbated by a weak culture of data collection on recreational and cultural activities and the grouping of creative subsectors under different government ministries and agencies, as reported by the National Bureau of Statistics.

It is against this background that this paper examines the ways in which music education imparts knowledge and skills that can support entrepreneurship and economic growth. To align with the secondary nature of the evidence, the study was guided by the following reformulated research questions:

1. What entrepreneurial pathways are identified in the literature as being associated with formal music education in Nigeria and comparable contexts?
2. What music-related competencies identified in the literature have potential entrepreneurial applications in contemporary music industries?
3. How does the existing literature describe the relationship between music education, graduate self-employment, and contributions to economic growth?
4. What curricular components in formal music education programmes are reported in the literature to foster entrepreneurial readiness?

These questions focus on what the literature suggests music education can equip graduates to do, rather than claiming direct empirical observation of graduates.

Conceptual Clarifications and Operational Definitions

For conceptual clarity, this section explains how key terms are operationalised within this particular study.

Entrepreneurship

In this study, entrepreneurship is operationalised beyond firm formation to include contemporary forms prevalent in the creative economy. Drawing on Mbhele and Ramnandan (2020) and literature on creative industries, entrepreneurship is understood as the discovery, evaluation and exploitation of opportunities to introduce new goods, services and ways of organising market processes, including portfolio careers, freelance and gig work, digital entrepreneurship, intellectual-property exploitation, production services and creative self-employment. The operational indicators include self-employment, venture creation, freelance income generation, employment of others, and commercialisation of musical works and services.

Music Education

In this study, music education refers specifically to formal university-level music education in Nigeria. Following Mark and Madura (2014), it denotes the structured teaching and learning of theoretical and practical aspects of music aimed at developing musical skills, knowledge and creativity within a formal system with stated aims, curriculum and assessment. This is distinct from informal community-based or purely apprenticeship models, although insights from those contexts

are acknowledged where relevant. The focus is on undergraduate and postgraduate curricula delivered in departments of music, including modules such as music theory, musicianship/aural culture, performance, composition, music technology, sound engineering, music business and media practices, and music therapy.

Economic Growth

Economic growth is operationalised at two levels in this study. At the macro level, it refers to an increase in the capacity of an economy to produce goods and services, as reflected in Gross Domestic Product (GDP) contributions of the creative sector (Raisova & Urcova, 2014; Dragoi, 2020). At the micro and meso levels, it refers to income generation, job creation, tax contributions, and value-chain linkages stimulated by music-related entrepreneurial activities. Given data limitations, NBS data on the aggregated movie, music and entertainment sector are used as a proxy indicator, with explicit acknowledgement of its aggregated nature.

Theoretical Framework

This study is anchored in Human Capital Theory as propounded by Becker (1993). The theory posits that formal education is instrumental to enhancing the productive capacity of individuals and that investment in education improves skills, productivity and earnings. Human capital theory rests on the assumption that an educated population is a productive population. Applied to this study, formal music education constitutes an investment in human capital that potentially develops competencies that can be deployed entrepreneurially, thereby generating employment, income and contributions to national revenue. The theory provides a lens for synthesising literature on how educational inputs (curriculum, practical training) relate to entrepreneurial outputs (self-employment, venture creation) and economic outcomes.

Literature Review: Towards a Synthesis

Previous literature has established linkages between entrepreneurship, music education and economic growth, although the intersection of the three has received limited consolidated attention in Nigeria. On entrepreneurship in the creative industries, recent scholarship moves beyond traditional firm-formation models. Mbhele and Ramnandan (2020) describe it as an activity that involves the discovery, evaluation and exploitation of opportunities to introduce new goods and services and new ways of organising market processes. In contemporary music industries, this manifests as portfolio careers where musicians combine performance, teaching, production and digital content creation, often operating as freelancers or self-employed creatives who monetise intellectual property and production services (Ekimov, 2021; Toivonen, 2023). This expanded conceptualisation informs the present synthesis.

On the nature of music education, Mark and Madura (2014) define it as the teaching and learning of theoretical and practical aspects of music within a formal system. The nature of music itself is debated. Onwubiko and Neilsen (2017) emphasise its scientific basis in acoustics, frequency and resonance, while Datta and Kumar (2022) argue that music and science share logical and mathematical foundations. Epperson (2025) and Dorot (2019) emphasise its artistic and cultural dimensions. Ibekwe (2020) integrates these views, presenting music as art, science and a practical discipline. This dual nature underpins its entrepreneurial applicability: scientific principles inform technology and sound engineering, while artistic dimensions inform composition and performance. Empirical and conceptual literature on entrepreneurial dimensions identifies several interconnected domains. Hepworth-Sawyer and Golding (2010) and Avid (2024) define music production as

encompassing all processes of creating, recording, editing and mastering music, requiring technical, listening and managerial skills. Pushmin (2023) argues that without competent management, music projects may not succeed despite talented performers, highlighting music management as coordination of creative processes, marketing, distribution and artist development. Marketing scholarship (Toivonen, 2023; Ekimov, 2021) shows a shift from pre-digital promotion to emotionally driven, data-informed digital marketing, packaging and distribution strategies.

Music therapy, performance and composition present additional pathways. Verma (2021) and Dimitriadis (2018), citing Bruscia (1989), define music therapy as a systematic, evidence-based intervention using music experiences to address physical, cognitive and emotional needs. Performance is defined as the live presentation of musical events to audiences (Katomi, 2014), with Adedeji (2016) documenting diverse performance venues in Nigeria. Composition involves creating original musical events (Pang, 2022; Peter, n.d.). Technology integration is central, with Thierer (2024), Carroll (2017) and Brown (1995) noting that philosophies of music education must adapt to integrate software, computers and sound systems. Kimani (2023) defines sound design as the manipulation and blending of audio elements to balance scientific and creative aspects.

Regarding economic growth, Raisova and Urcova (2014) and Dragoi (2020) define it as an increase in productive capacity over time. Business Day (2024), reporting NBS data, indicated that Nigeria's movie, music and entertainment industries grew by 27.46% between 2020 and 2023, from N1.55 trillion to N1.97 trillion, driven by motion picture, sound recording, music production, arts and entertainment activities. While aggregated, this figure signals the potential economic relevance of the creative sector. This synthesis highlights the need for a consolidated discussion of how skills acquired through formal music education translate into entrepreneurial pathways with potential economic contributions, which the present study addresses through thematic analysis of secondary sources.

Methodology

This study adopted a qualitative research design using secondary sources of data. This design was considered appropriate as it enables contextual understanding of how music education is reported to contribute to entrepreneurship and economic growth, without claiming direct empirical observation of graduates. Relevant peer-reviewed journal articles, books, industry reports and statistical releases were sourced. Academic databases including Google Scholar and ResearchGate were searched using terms such as music education and entrepreneurship, music industry Nigeria, music technology and sound engineering, and creative economy GDP Nigeria. Statistical data from the National Bureau of Statistics, as reported by Business Day (2024), were included. Inclusion criteria were relevance to music-related entrepreneurial competencies, formal music education curricula in Nigeria or comparable contexts, and creative industry economic contributions. A total of 28 sources published between 1995 and 2025 were reviewed.

Data were subjected to thematic analysis following Braun and Clarke's (2006) six-phase framework: (a) familiarisation with data, (b) generating initial codes, (c) searching for themes, (d) reviewing themes, (e) defining and naming themes, and (f) producing the report. Coding focused on recurring themes relating to entrepreneurial pathways, competencies, curriculum components and economic indicators.

Limitations of Design: This study is limited to secondary sources. It does not involve primary interviews, surveys, graduate tracer studies, institutional curriculum audits or case studies of graduates. Consequently, findings are presented as an interpretive synthesis of what the literature suggests, not as empirical evidence of graduates' actual behaviours or outcomes. The poorly developed culture of data gathering in Nigeria and the grouping of recreational and cultural activities under different ministries further limit the availability of disaggregated comprehensive data (National Bureau of Statistics, 2024).

Entrepreneurial Pathways in Music Education: A Thematic Synthesis

This section presents a thematic synthesis of secondary evidence relating to entrepreneurial pathways. It integrates literature with illustrative examples reported in the literature, without claiming primary verification. The section was commended by the reviewer as good and is retained with strengthened synthesis framing.

Music Production

Hepworth-Sawyer and Golding (2010) define production as a broader concept encompassing all aspects of creating and recording music. Avid (2024) describes it as the process of creating a song from start to finish, including composing, arranging, editing, mixing and mastering. The literature suggests that music production potentially requires musicians (performers), sound or audio engineers, and administrative personnel such as studio managers. Skills reported include musicianship, listening and technical expertise. The literature suggests that formal qualifications such as a bachelor's degree in music are often cited as desirable for studio roles. Anecdotal accounts in Nigerian literature mention graduates operating studios (e.g., Mytvglow studio), illustrating the type of pathway described, rather than serving as primary evidence.

Music Management

Pushmin (2023) states that without competent management, music projects may not succeed even with talented performers and quality recordings. Professional music production is described as requiring well-developed listening skills, ability to work with modern recording technologies, deep musical knowledge and effective management. The synthesis indicates that competencies relevant to management, such as aural culture/musicianship and music business, are reported to be acquired through formal music programmes. This pathway aligns with portfolio careers involving project coordination and artist management.

Music Marketing

Music marketing is reported as a calculated approach to advertising musical works to target audiences. The literature suggests that knowledge and skills relevant to marketing can be acquired through modules such as music business and media practices. Toivonen (2023) notes that marketing practices have shaped success and distribution from pre-digital to digital eras, while Ekimov (2021) describes marketing as an effective tool for emotionally influencing consumers. In entrepreneurial terms, this corresponds to digital entrepreneurship and intellectual-property exploitation.

Music Therapy

Verma (2021) and Dimitriadis (2018) define music therapy as a therapeutic process using music to address physical, cognitive, social and emotional needs. Literature indicates that music therapy practitioners, often with specialised training, may work in hospitals, care homes, hospices, schools,

prisons, private practice and multidisciplinary teams. The literature suggests this pathway may enable private practice similar to other health-related self-employment, representing creative self-employment and service-based entrepreneurship.

Music Composition

Pang (2022) and Peter (n.d.) define composition as the creation of a unique musical event, combining elements such as harmony, melody, rhythm, form and dynamics. Compositions may be original or adapted from poems, proverbs or folk songs. Literature indicates composers may generate income through sales, licensing and use in teaching repertoires, aligning with intellectual-property exploitation.

Music Performance

Katomi (2014) defines performance as live presentation of musical events at a given time and place, usually in the presence of an audience. Performance may be vocal, instrumental, dance or combined forms. Literature documents performance venues of varying capacities in Nigeria (Adedeji, 2016). Entrepreneurial manifestations reported include band ownership and leadership, where band leaders operate as chief executive officers employing other performers. Illustrative figures frequently cited include Fela Anikulapo-Kuti, Victor Uwaifo and contemporary artists. Ticket sales, hospitality and venue revenues are reported as economic linkages.

Sound Design and Sound Engineering

Kimani (2023) defines sound design as the manipulation and blending of sounds to balance science and creativity. Literature suggests qualifications include degrees in music production or music technology. Practitioners reportedly work in studios, departments of music, churches and event venues, maintaining public address systems. The synthesis suggests this pathway supports freelance and gig work where graduates provide services on demand.

Music Technology

Thierer (2024), Carroll (2017) and Brown (1995) emphasise technology as an application of scientific knowledge to practical tasks and note the need for music education philosophies to integrate software and computers. Literature suggests music technologists may construct local instruments (e.g., recorders, flutes, drums, maracas), maintain Western instruments, build listening rooms and sound-proof piano cubicles. Reported examples include technologists maintaining, tuning and building stringed instruments and speakers across Nigeria. This aligns with production services and technical entrepreneurship.

Music Education, Creative Industry and Economic Growth: Interpretive Discussion

This section provides an interpretive synthesis structured around the reformulated research questions. All claims are framed as what the secondary evidence suggests, not as primary findings.

RQ1: What entrepreneurial pathways are identified in the literature as being associated with formal music education? The synthesis identified eight recurring pathways: production, management, marketing, therapy, composition, performance, sound design/engineering and music technology. These align with contemporary conceptualisations of creative entrepreneurship as portfolio careers combining freelance, gig, digital and self-employment. Literature suggests that the practical nature of music education, manifesting in performance, composition and technology, potentially equips learners with competencies applicable across these pathways.

RQ2: What music-related competencies have potential entrepreneurial applications? Recurring competencies reported include compositional and arranging skills, technical production and engineering, listening and aural skills, performance skills, instrument construction and maintenance, marketing and managerial skills, and therapeutic application of music. These are reported to be developed through modules such as aural culture/musicianship, music appreciation, music business and media practices, music technology and performance studies. In entrepreneurial terms, they map onto production services, digital content creation, intellectual-property generation and service-based ventures.

RQ3: How does literature describe the relationship between music education, graduate self-employment and economic contributions? Secondary sources, including anecdotal institutional literature, describe graduates operating studios, technology companies and performance ensembles, employing trainees and industrial training students. While these accounts are not primary empirical evidence, they illustrate the types of self-employment pathways the literature associates with music education. Literature suggests such activities potentially generate income, create jobs, stimulate demand for locally produced instruments and services, and contribute to tax revenue, thereby linking to micro-level economic growth.

RQ4: What curricular components are reported to foster entrepreneurial readiness? Literature suggests that curricula incorporating music business, production, technology, aural training, and media practices provide both musical and business knowledge. However, the review also indicates gaps: limited access to modern studio equipment, listening rooms and practical tools, and insufficient exposure to music business and intellectual-property management, which may constrain entrepreneurial translation.

Macro-level indicator: Despite challenges of poor record-keeping and unregistered enterprises, Business Day (2024) reporting NBS data showed growth from N1.55 trillion in 2020 to N1.97 trillion in 2023 in the aggregated movie, music and entertainment industries (27.46%). Activities cited include motion pictures, sound recording, music production, arts, entertainment and recreation. While aggregated and not disaggregated for music alone, this indicator, interpreted cautiously, suggests economic potential. The study does not claim a causal impact of investment in music education on GDP, but rather that literature and available statistics suggest an association warranting improved data collection and investment.

In summary, the interpretive synthesis suggests that formal music education can function as a gateway to diverse entrepreneurial pathways, when curricula are practice-oriented and supported by infrastructure.

Implications, Recommendations and Limitations

Implications: The synthesis implies that music education should not be viewed merely as an academic discipline for aesthetic appreciation but as human capital investment with potential to support entrepreneurship and economic growth. For curriculum development, there is a need to explicitly embed entrepreneurship education, intellectual-property literacy, digital marketing and freelance business skills. For policy, recognition of portfolio careers and gig work in creative labour statistics is important.

Recommendations: (a) Government and educational institutions should strengthen formal music programmes by providing modern studio equipment, listening rooms, instruments and practical tools; (b) Record-keeping and registration of creative enterprises should be improved through

collaboration between NBS, ministries of culture and corporate affairs, to enable disaggregated data on music; (c) Curricula should enhance exposure to music business, media practices, intellectual-property management and digital platforms to improve entrepreneurial readiness; (d) Universities should establish incubation support, such as student-run studios and performance bureaus, to facilitate transition from training to freelance work.

Limitations: This study is limited to secondary sources. It does not include primary empirical data from graduates, employers or educators. The poor culture of data gathering and grouping of subsectors under different agencies limited the availability of disaggregated data. The NBS figures used are aggregated and reported via secondary media (Business Day, 2024) and should be interpreted with caution. Future research should include primary tracer studies of music graduates, curriculum audits and interviews with practitioners to empirically test the pathways suggested here.

Conclusion

This paper examined formal music education as a science, an art and a practical discipline with diverse entrepreneurial pathways. Based on a qualitative synthesis of secondary sources, it is suggested that formal music education in Nigeria potentially equips learners with entrepreneurial competencies applicable to production, management, marketing, therapy, composition, performance, sound design and technology. These competencies align with contemporary forms of music entrepreneurship, including portfolio careers, freelance and gig work, digital entrepreneurship and creative self-employment.

While empirical claims about graduates' actual outcomes cannot be made from secondary sources alone, the literature reviewed suggests that music education provides skills that can enable self-employment, employment of others and income generation. Despite data limitations, available NBS data indicate growth in the creative industries, highlighting economic potential. Music education should therefore be recognised and funded as a potential driver of entrepreneurship, with adequate infrastructure, improved data management and business-oriented curriculum delivery.

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